Croatia: energy security, economic opportunity and partnership priorities

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AI-generated from the data and checked against it; paper baseline as of 12 October 2026.

Summary

- Croatia is most exposed in upstream coal, upstream electric grid and downstream nuclear, with Energy Security higher than only 12%, 15% and 26% of the other economies scored. In upstream electric grid, a trade deficit pulls the score down.[1]
- Its strongest openings are in upstream solar, midstream nuclear and midstream coal, with Economic Opportunity higher than 93%, 88% and 87% of the other economies scored, mainly through trade.[1]
- On the paper's weighting, its top Strategic Index sectors are upstream nuclear, downstream batteries and upstream batteries, almost tied. In upstream batteries, midstream batteries, midstream electric grid and midstream solar, top priority meets the most policy.[1]
- The Partnership Strength Index rates Germany highest, followed by Austria. Germany is also its 1st trade partner, while Bosnia and Herzegovina and Turkiye are each a strong tie today that the index ranks lower.[1,2]

1. Energy security risks and why

14 of Croatia's 30 placed sectors, those whose scores can be compared with other economies, sit in the two low-energy-security corners. Energy Security measures how well a country can rely on what it needs in a sector. Compared with other economies, its Energy Security is lowest in upstream coal, upstream electric grid, downstream nuclear and downstream coal. Its scores there are higher than only 12%, 15%, 26% and 28% of the other 95, 93, 66 and 98 economies scored in these sectors. Of these, upstream coal and upstream electric grid sit in the Upgrade corner, and downstream nuclear and downstream coal in the Secure corner.[1]

The data's high-priority sectors, its Upgrade sectors with the best Strategic Index ranks, are upstream batteries, upstream electric grid and upstream green hydrogen. In upstream electric grid the score is 0.32, and trade pulls it down. Its trade deficit in these goods was 0.5% of GDP in 2023; on this measure it scores higher than only 2% of the other economies. For context, of its USD 515 m of imports of these goods in 2024, Slovenia supplied 33.6%, Bulgaria 21.6% and Bosnia and Herzegovina 9.3%. In upstream green hydrogen, which scores 0.18, minerals trade pulls the score down: its share of world exports of the technology's minerals was <0.1% in 2024.[1,2,3,4]

In upstream coal, trade pulls the score down too: the deficit was 0.5% of GDP in 2023. For context, its largest suppliers were Colombia (41.8%) and Kazakhstan (32.4%). In downstream coal, energy access pulls the score down: coal use per person changed by -34.8% over the years to 2025, to 2.49 GJ per person.[2,3,5]

2. Economic opportunities and why

23 of the 30 placed sectors sit in the two high-opportunity corners. Economic Opportunity measures how well placed a country is to create value in a sector. Compared with other economies, it is highest in upstream solar, midstream nuclear, midstream coal and downstream solar, higher than 93%, 88%, 87% and 84% of the other economies scored. All sit in the Grow corner, which the paper's framework associates with export promotion.[1]

In upstream solar, trade pushes the score up: its revealed comparative advantage, the weight of these goods in its exports relative to world exports, was 7.66 in 2024. Its share of world exports was 0.8% in 2023. For context, Italy took 80.4% of its exports of these goods in 2024.[2,3,6]

In midstream nuclear and midstream coal, trade also pushes the score up, with revealed comparative advantages of 2.98 and 2.66 in 2024. For context, the largest market for its midstream nuclear exports was the United States (39.4%). In downstream solar, investment and energy access push the score up. On growth in investment it scores higher than 85% of the other economies, and solar power use per person changed by 1313.2% over the years to 2025, to 1.23 GJ per person.[1,2,5,6]

3. Sectoral priorities and the existing policy posture

The Strategic Index ranks a country's own sectors by opportunity, security need, policy activity, stage and low-emission value. On the paper's weighting, it ranks upstream nuclear 1st, downstream batteries 2nd, upstream batteries 3rd, upstream solar 4th and midstream batteries 5th among Croatia's own sectors. With 0.66, upstream nuclear leads, almost tied with downstream batteries; the gaps between neighbours are 0.001, 0.003, 0.011 and 0.002. Priority, the index without its policy term, also puts upstream nuclear 1st, but downstream batteries only 13th; policy activity lifts the latter. For upstream batteries, in the Upgrade corner that the paper's framework links to building domestic capability, security need adds 0.238, against 0.137 for opportunity.[1]

The allied pick, the leading upstream or midstream sector after a screen for resource endowment, is midstream batteries (0.64), 0.023 ahead of midstream electric grid. The screen leaves out upstream nuclear, upstream batteries and upstream solar, with no recorded resource base.[7]

Policy activity counts International Energy Agency Policies and Measures records and reads the Climate Action Tracker rating against each technology. Croatia carries the rating Insufficient (November 2024) and has 81 such records, 39 of which name a technology. Top priority meets the most policy in upstream batteries, midstream batteries, midstream electric grid and midstream solar. It meets only middle policy in upstream nuclear, upstream electric grid, upstream solar, upstream green hydrogen, upstream wind and midstream green hydrogen, and never the least policy. In downstream green hydrogen, bottom priority meets the most policy. Priority and policy agree at the bottom in 7 sectors, every coal and oil sector among them.[1,8,9]

4. Partnership priorities and why

The Partnership Strength Index rates partners as reliable suppliers (Friendshore), as export markets (Partnership Opportunity) and, for middle- and lower-income partners, by Development Potential. From Croatia's viewpoint it ranks Germany 1st, Austria 2nd, Slovenia 3rd, Italy 4th and the Netherlands 5th of 191 partners. Germany, Slovenia and the Netherlands each stand out as an export market; for Germany the best

sectors are midstream wind, upstream solar, midstream electric grid, midstream solar and midstream batteries. Austria and Italy each stand out as a reliable supplier.[1]

Today's trade matches this list closely. Germany is Croatia's 1st trade partner on average across its energy-goods baskets, Italy its 2nd, Slovenia its 3rd, the Netherlands its 5th and Austria its 7th; each is a priority partner with strong ties today. All of these partners vote in the same bloc as Croatia at the UN, and all but Austria share membership of NATO with it. By contrast, Bosnia and Herzegovina is its 9th trade partner but ranks 28th on Partnership Strength, and Turkiye is its 10th but ranks 43rd. In UN votes, Croatia is U.S.-leaning, while Bosnia and Herzegovina and Turkiye are each nonaligned.[1,2,10,11]

As a partner to the coalition, Croatia ranks 32nd of 192 economies on Partnership Strength averaged over the core members' viewpoints. In the allied network design, which spreads upstream and midstream production across coalition members, its largest designed shares are 0.7% of upstream solar and 0.2% of midstream wind.[1,7]

5. Data notes and caveats

Values are as of 12 October 2026; Country Insights has more.

- Scores compare Croatia with other economies in the same sector; they are not measures of risk or profit in absolute terms.
- All index values are the paper's baseline as of 12 October 2026; Strategic Insights recomputes them under other weightings.
- Strategic Index scores within 0.01 of each other are almost tied: small changes in the data or the weights can swap their order.
- Many allied picks are close calls: in the paper, 37% of them are within 0.01 of the runner-up.
- In the allied network design the European Union is one producer; Croatia's shares are derived from its weight within the EU.
- The Climate Action Tracker rates the EU as a whole; Croatia carries the EU's rating.
- Croatia's counts leave out the EU's own 438 International Energy Agency policy records.
- Trade figures count trade with other EU members.

Sources

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11. Economic-security agreements: G7, NATO, Indo-Pacific Economic Framework, Minerals Security Partnership (and Forum), U.S. free-trade agreements (compiled by the authors from official membership lists).

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Allied Industrial Base Explorer, Country Insights: Croatia